ADAM DJ BRETT AND BETTY HILL (LYONS)

REFLECTIONS AND NEXT STEPS ON THE RELIGIOUS ORIGINS OF WHITE SUPREMACY: REFLECTIONS ON JOHNSON V. M'INTOSH AND THE DOCTRINE OF CHRISTIAN DISCOVERY

Abstract

This reflective section revisits the central themes and insights from the examination of the religious origins of white supremacy through the lens of *Johnson v. M'Intosh* and the Doctrine of Christian Discovery (DoCD). By foregrounding the theological and legal roots of racial hierarchy, contributors assess the ongoing influence of the DoCD as both a historical construct and a living framework shaping Indigenous dispossession and systemic inequality. The reflections synthesize diverse scholarly and activist perspectives from the conference, interrogating how Euro-Christian imperial values continue to inform law, education, and national narratives. Emphasis is placed on the necessity of confronting foundational myths, legal fictions, and religious doctrines that maintain structures of domination. The section also identifies actionable pathways for resisting and dismantling these systems, including the development of decolonial legal, theological, and pedagogical initiatives. It highlights the importance of coalition-building across Indigenous nations, academic disciplines, and advocacy groups, insisting that future work requires sustained commitment to relationality, accountability, and justice. This section calls for a deepened engagement with Indigenous epistemologies and the cultivation of ethical relationships as essential steps in moving beyond critique to transformative practice and systemic change.

Keyword: *religious studies, critical indigenous studies, international law*

Starting in 2010 the American Indian Law Alliance, Indigenous Values Initiative, Syracuse University, and other organizations like American Indian Community House, Tonatierra, and Sacred Places Institute have been collaborating formally and informally through the Doctrine of Discovery Project and Working Group. The project and its website (doctrineofdiscovery.org) were started by Prof. Philip P. Arnold and Sandra Bigtree (Mohawk Nation). Through this expansive collaboration conferences have been able to be held on dismantling the Doctrine of Discovery on a semi-annual basis. This year's conference which was generously supported and funded by sponsors like The Henry Luce Foundation, Syracuse University Departments of Religion and Biology, Indigenous Values Initiative, American Indian Law Alliance, American Indian Community House, Good Faith Media (GFM), Neighbors of Onondaga Nation (NOON), Syracuse Peace Council, Syracuse Cultural Workers, Tonatierra, Toward Our Common Public Life and the Unitarian Universalist Association. Here are some of our reflections on this important conference and convening.

Defining the Doctrine of Christian Discovery

The Doctrine of Christian Discovery, often referred to simply as the Doctrine of Discovery, is a theological and legal framework that emerged from a series of 15th-century papal bulls. These papal declarations authorized Christian monarchs to seize lands inhabited by non-Christians, subject those populations to European sovereignty, and legitimize conquest and colonization under the guise of evangelization. Most notably, Pope Nicholas V's 1452 *Dum Diversas* and Pope Alexander VI's 1493 *Inter Caetera* instructed Christian rulers to "invade, capture, vanquish, and subdue" non-Christian peoples and to "reduce their persons to perpetual slavery."[1] These documents laid the moral and legal foundation for European imperial expansion. At the conference there was an interest in enhancing the work done by Steven T. Newcomb (Shawnee/Lenape) and to not only trace the Domination framework from the start of Constantinian Christianity to the Crusades, the Age of Conquest and Colonization, to today but also to provide side by side scholarly translations with a transcript on the verso and the translation on the verso.[2] Doing a book like this would allow students, scholars, and activists to join Newcomb in examining the Domination Code and its attendant framework, thereby allowing for a more detailed enhanced and robust accounting of dominion theology and the Doctrine of Discovery. Our colleague Sebastain Modrow has undertaken starting a significant part of this task with doing an updated translation of the bulls starting with the Canary Island bulls of the 1300s and working forward to *Inter Caetera* (which he and Melissa Smith have already completed).

Providing a detailed theological, ideological, and linguistic analysis of the effective history of Doctrine of Discovery helps to further contest and challenge the past and present embedding of Christian hegemony through law and policy not only nationally but also internationally. This religious justification for conquest was secularized and embedded in American jurisprudence in the 1823 Supreme Court case *Johnson v. M'Intosh*. Chief Justice John Marshall

---

[1] Nicholas V, "Dum Diversas," in *Bullarium Patronatus Portugalliae Regum: In Ecclesiis Africae, Asiae Atque Oceaniae*, trans. Levy Maria Jordão, vol. 1, 22–23 (1872), https://aila.li/nicholas/; Nicholas V, "Romanus Pontifex," *Doctrine of Discovery Project*, https://doctrineofdiscovery.org/the-bull-romanus-pontifex-nicholas-v/; Frances Gardiner Davenport, ed., "The Bull Romanus Pontifex, January 8, 1455," in *European Treaties Bearing on the History of the United States and Its Dependencies,* 9–27 (Carnegie Institution of Washington, 1917), http://archive.org/details/eurotreatiesus00daverich; Sebastian Modrow and Melissa Smith, "The Papal Bull Inter Caetera of May 4, 1493: Introduced and Translated by Sebastian Modrow and Melissa Smith," *Doctrine of Discovery Project*, June 2022, https://doctrineofdiscovery.org/inter-caetera/.

[2] Steven T. Newcomb, Pagans in the Promised Land: Decoding the Doctrine of Christian Discovery (Fulcrum Publishing, 2008); Sheldon P. Wolfchild, dir., The Doctrine of Discovery: Unmasking the Domination Code, documentary film (38 Plus 2 Productions, 2015), https://vimeo.com/ondemand/dominationcode.

ruled that the United States inherited a European right of "discovery," granting dominion over Indigenous lands to Christian colonizing powers and denying land rights to Indigenous nations. This ruling remains a bedrock of U.S. property law, cited as recently as 2005 in *City of Sherrill v. Oneida Indian Nation*.

As Philip P. Arnold summarized at the conference in December 2023, the Doctrine of Discovery represents a "theology of oppression and world domination" that fuses religious supremacy with legal and territorial conquest. It continues to shape Indigenous dispossession globally, long after its explicitly religious language faded from political discourse.[3]

Haudenosaunee and Māori Contributions to the Conference

The Haudenosaunee Confederacy played a central role in the Syracuse University conference, not only as hosts but as intellectual and spiritual leaders. The Onondaga Nation, where Syracuse University stands, is the central fire of the Confederacy. Speakers reminded attendees that the Haudenosaunee form of governance, grounded in the Great Law of Peace, directly influenced the U.S. Constitution. Yet, as Sandy Bigtree and Betty Lyons emphasized, that same constitution was built upon legal doctrines that deny the sovereignty of the very peoples who inspired it.

Haudenosaunee contributions to the conference highlighted traditional ecological knowledge, the diplomatic legacy of figures like Deskaheh (Cayuga Nation) and Oren Lyons (Onondaga Nation), and the enduring strength of Indigenous governance structures. The presence of Māori representatives further expanded the conference's international scope. They shared parallels between the Treaty of Waitangi and U.S. treaties, demonstrating how the Doctrine of Discovery undergirded colonial violence in Aotearoa New Zealand, just as it did in North America.

The conference fostered a trans-Indigenous dialogue across hemispheres, rooted in mutual recognition of colonization's legal and religious architecture. Participants from both traditions advocated for the recovery of Indigenous legal orders as a necessary counter to the Christian imperial legal legacy. The concluding Māori performance and traditional Haudenosaunee Thanksgiving Address grounded the conference in ceremonial respect, reinforcing that Indigenous law and spiritual practice continue to thrive despite centuries of attempted erasure.

Robert P. Jones and Anthea Butler on White Supremacy

Two of the conference's most influential intellectual voices were Robert P. Jones and Anthea Butler, whose works anchor contemporary analyses of white Christian supremacy. Jones, author of *The Hidden Roots of White Supremacy*, argues that American religious history cannot be understood apart from its entanglement with racial domination. As he explained in his conference presentation, the Doctrine of Discovery is not merely an antiquated theological concept, but a living ideology embedded in U.S. law, culture, and theology.[4]

Jones links the papal bulls and Marshall's ruling to a broader American narrative that fuses Christianity with civilizational superiority. He notes how the language of "civilization" and "Christianity" continues to justify the marginalization of non-white, non-Christian populations.

---

[3] Philip P. Arnold and Sandra L. Bigtree, "Episode 0: Introduction to Mapping the Doctrine of Discovery Podcast," *Mapping the Doctrine of Discovery Podcast*, February 12, 2022, https://podcast.doctrineofdiscovery.org/season1/episode-0/.

[4] Robert P. Jones, The Hidden Roots of White Supremacy: And the Path to a Shared American Future (Simon and Schuster, 2024); Anthea D. Butler, White Evangelical Racism: The Politics of Morality in America (The University of North Carolina Press, 2021), https://search.ebscohost.com/login.aspx?direct=true&scope=site&db=nlebk&db=nlabk&AN=2757740.

Anthea Butler, author of *White Evangelical Racism*, critiques how evangelical theology has historically buttressed racism under the guise of religious piety. Although her primary focus is evangelicalism, her framework applies more broadly to the religious legitimation of white supremacy. Together, Butler and Jones provide a critical lens for understanding how American Christianity has served as an instrument of racial and colonial power.

Their contributions at the conference helped illuminate the continuity between religious conquest in the 15th century and contemporary forms of Christian nationalism and racial exclusion. As noted in several student and scholar reflections, one cannot separate legal structures from the cultural theology that gave them moral authority—this is the true power of the Doctrine of Discovery.

International Dimensions of the Doctrine of Discovery: International Human Rights

Together with our dear friend and colleague Eve Reyes-Aguirre (Izkaloteka Azteca) we presented on the international struggle to challenge the Doctrine of Discovery that has deep historical roots and remains constrained by the colonial logic that underpins international law. The Haudenosaunee Confederacy has long asserted its sovereignty beyond settler state frameworks. In 1923, Chief Deskaheh of the Cayuga Nation traveled to the League of Nations in Geneva, Switzerland, to demand recognition of Haudenosaunee sovereignty, the right to practice traditional governance, and the freedom to maintain religious and legal traditions. Despite Deskaheh's appeal, the League refused to hear him. He was exiled from his homeland and died in Buffalo, New York, cut off from his family and community. This early effort marked a foundational episode in Indigenous diplomacy.[5]

The exclusion of Indigenous Peoples from formal structures of international law continues today. International law recognizes settler colonial states—not peoples or Indigenous nations—as legal actors. Even foundational instruments like the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP), adopted in 2007, are not legally binding. UNDRIP was supported by 144 countries, but four settler states—Canada, the U.S., New Zealand, and Australia—voted against it, demonstrating the resistance of colonial powers to Indigenous self-determination. Although UNDRIP represents a moral victory, it is not a convention and cannot compel state compliance. Article 46, in particular, limits the rights expressed in Articles 1 through 45 by preserving the territorial integrity of states, which effectively reaffirms settler sovereignty over Indigenous lands.[6]

This structural limitation reveals the deeper problem: international law emerged from a context of domination and supremacy. It was designed to protect colonial powers, not the peoples they colonized. Thus, general human rights conventions—such as the Universal Declaration of Human Rights—fail to protect Indigenous peoples, women, and children. This is why specialized conventions, like the Convention on the Elimination of All Forms of Discrimination Against Women (CEDAW) and the Convention on the Rights of the Child (CRC), are essential. These groups face unique harms that general frameworks ignore or downplay. Indigenous women, for instance, endure both racialized and gendered violence—often at the hands of both Indigenous and non-Indigenous men. Betty and Eve have spoken

---

[5] Deskaheh, "The Redman's Appeal for Justice," DOCIP, August 6, 1923, CENDOC - DOCIP, http://cendoc.docip.org/collect/deskaheh/index/assoc/HASH0102/5e23c4be.dir/R612-11-28075-30626-8.pdf; DOCIP, "Historical Process at the United Nations," Blog, *Indigenous Peoples Center For Documentation Research And Information (DOCIP)*, n.d., accessed January 1, 2025, https://www.docip.org/en/oral-history-and-memory/historical-process/.

[6] Duane Champagne, "UNDRIP (United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples): Human, Civil, and Indigenous Rights," *Wicazo Sa Review* 28, no. 1 (2013): 9–22.

openly about sexism experienced from both groups, including within diplomatic spaces such as the United Nations.

Internalized patriarchy and lateral violence are also a major concern. Colonial systems have taught some Indigenous men—and even women—to replicate patterns of domination and silence within their own communities. Sadly these issues become all to present at the UN Permanent Forum on Indigenous Issues (UNPFII) where women like Betty and Eve find their voices and often literal presence dismissed from the room. Additionally Indigenous Water Protectors and activists find themselves and threats of physical violence and harm in these hallowed halls and on the streets of New York from multi-national corporations and member states. This is why affirming the rights of women, children, and Mother Earth is vital. Rights are not just legal constructs; they are reflections of our relationships. Territorial integrity should apply not only to settler states but to the Earth itself. The call to respect the rights of Mother Earth echoes Indigenous legal traditions and spiritual obligations that predate Western notions of sovereignty.

These themes were present in the 23rd Session of the United Nations Permanent Forum on Indigenous Issues (UNPFII) in 2024. The session emphasized Indigenous youth voices, intergenerational wisdom, and Indigenous-led education. It also highlighted ongoing problems: the criminalization of Indigenous rights defenders, child removals that perpetuate intergenerational trauma, and lack of access to culturally grounded healthcare and education. There were also repeated calls to honor UNDRIP and implement it through binding policies, especially in areas impacted by extractive industries and militarization.

International law and policy often fail to meet the needs of Indigenous nations and peoples. Though many global bodies, such as the United Nations, claim to support Indigenous rights, these claims lack enforcement power. Indigenous nations are routinely excluded from international decision-making, despite having unique worldviews, governance structures, and relationships with the land that do not fit neatly within Western frameworks.

A key example is the United Nations Declaration on the Rights of Indigenous Peoples (UNDRIP). UNDRIP is widely celebrated as a landmark document, but it is not legally binding. While it affirms collective rights—such as self-determination and territorial claims—it lacks enforcement mechanisms. Without ratification as a binding covenant, member states can choose to ignore its provisions. Thus, despite symbolic victories, UNDRIP remains a tool of advocacy, not enforcement.

UNDRIP also does not fully escape the limitations of the broader human rights framework. International law tends to privilege Christian, Western forms of religious expression—those with churches, clergy, and written doctrines. Indigenous peoples, whose traditions often defy these institutional categories, find themselves left out or misrepresented.[7]

Furthermore, international law rarely recognizes Indigenous peoples as sovereign nations. Instead, it often treats them as minorities within nation-states. This undermines their autonomy and erases their treaty relationships. For example, U.S. federal Indian law is rooted in the Doctrine of Discovery, a legal and theological framework that justifies the domination

[7] Adam DJ Brett and Betty Hill (Lyons), "Documenting Domination: From the Doctrine of Christian Discovery to Dominion Theology," *Religions* 15, no. 12 (2024), https://doi.org/10.3390/rel15121493; Adam DJ Brett and Betty Hill (Lyons), "On the Limits of the Concept of Religious Freedom in Indigenous Communities," Articles, *Journal of the Council for Research on Religion* 5, no. 2 (2024): 75–96, https://doi.org/10.26443/jcreor.v5i2.117.

and dispossession of Indigenous lands. Treaties, though deemed "the supreme law of the land," are routinely ignored or reinterpreted by settler governments.[8]

Finally, many Indigenous advocates call for new frameworks that recognize the rights of Mother Earth and uphold traditional responsibilities to future generations. These values often do not fit within dominant rights-based systems, which emphasize individual freedoms over collective responsibilities. Until international law evolves to reflect these Indigenous worldviews—and until declarations like UNDRIP become enforceable—Indigenous nations remain vulnerable to systems of global injustice.[9]

Against these challenges, Indigenous visions like Tupac Enrique Acosta's (Izkaloteka Azteca) concept of "Superseding the Doctrine of Discovery" imagines an alternative future rooted in Indigenous unity, ecological reciprocity, and global Indigenous consciousness.[10] Similarly, the Two Row Wampum Treaty and the One Dish One Spoon agreement remind us of the enduring Haudenosaunee principles of coexistence and mutual respect—values that stand in sharp contrast to the hierarchical, extractive logic of the Doctrine of Discovery.

In sum, international human rights law offers tools but not solutions. It has yet to escape its roots in conquest. For true justice, we must listen to Indigenous nations as sovereigns, not stakeholders. That begins by centering Indigenous law, affirming treaties like the Two Row Wampum, and insisting that the Earth, like its peoples, has rights worth defending.

Oren Lyons and the Haudenosaunee International Legacy

Oren Lyons, Faithkeeper of the Turtle Clan of the Onondaga Nation, and a founding member of the United Nations Permanent Forum on Indigenous Issues, stood as a moral and intellectual pillar of the conference. His decades of international advocacy have helped frame the Doctrine of Discovery as not only a legal or theological problem, but a global human rights issue.[11] He was part of the delegation which traveled in Dakshesh's footsteps to Geneva in 1977 and has been a vocal advocate of Indigenous sovereignty and the right to self-determination.

Lyons reminded conference attendees that the Haudenosaunee Confederacy has always maintained a vision of global diplomacy grounded in peace, environmental stewardship, and spiritual sovereignty. He invoked the 1977 Geneva conference, when Haudenosaunee leaders traveled to the United Nations to deliver the *Basic Call to Consciousness*, a foundational text in the international Indigenous rights movement.[12]

Through Lyons' leadership, the Haudenosaunee have challenged the Vatican, the United States, and the international community to reckon with their complicity in Indigenous dispossession. Lyons's work insists that any real healing or justice requires not only recognition of historical wrongs, but systemic legal, political, and spiritual transformation. His presence at the conference served as a reminder that Indigenous diplomacy precedes and outlasts the colonial order.

---

[8] Betty Hill (Lyons), "Remarks on the Freedom of Religion or Belief Report," Articles, *Journal of the Council for Research on Religion* 5, no. 2 (2024): 54–57, https://doi.org/10.26443/jcreor.v5i2.115.

[9] Brett and Hill (Lyons), "Documenting Domination: From the Doctrine of Christian Discovery to Dominion Theology"; Brett and Hill (Lyons), "On the Limits of the Concept of Religious Freedom in Indigenous Communities."

[10] Tupac Enrique Acosta, "Superseding the Doctrine of Discovery: World Water One," *Doctrine of Discovery Project*, March 29, 2023, https://doctrineofdiscovery.org/blog/1CEMANAHUAC/.

[11] Oren Lyons, Exiled in the Land of the Free: Democracy, Indian Nations, and the U.S. Constitution (Clear Light Publishers, 1992).

[12] José Barreiro, Oren Lyons, and John Mohawk, *Basic Call to Consciousness*, rev. ed. (Akwesasne Notes Native Voices, 2005).

Moana Jackson and Māori International Legacy

Our dear friend and Māori thinker, Tina Ngata (Ngati Porou) brought print copies of her book *Kia Mau, Resisting Colonial Fictions* and spoke about her mentor Moana Jackson who recently joined the ancestors.[13] Moana Jackson played a pivotal role in advancing Māori and Indigenous understandings of the Doctrine of Discovery at the international level by connecting local struggles in Aotearoa (New Zealand) with global movements for Indigenous self-determination and constitutional transformation. As convenor of the Matike Mai Aotearoa Working Group on Constitutional Transformation, Jackson framed the doctrine not just as a legal tool of colonization but as a moral and constitutional injustice that continues to undermine Māori sovereignty.

Through this work, Jackson not only helped Māori reclaim constitutional discourse within Aotearoa but also helped embed Māori struggles within broader global movements for Indigenous justice, using international law and diplomacy as tools for collective resistance and vision-building. Like Oren Lyons, his work remains a touchstone for Indigenous constitutional theory worldwide.

Kia Mau

Tina Ngata's *Kia Mau* is a powerful critique of the ongoing colonial structures that shape the experiences of Indigenous peoples, particularly the Māori of Aotearoa (New Zealand). She argues that colonization is not a historical event but a continuing system of dispossession and control. The title, "Kia Mau," meaning "hold fast" in Māori, signals the imperative to remain grounded in Indigenous values and identities in the face of persistent colonial pressures.[14]

Ngata challenges the myths that uphold colonial authority, especially the narrative that colonization brought civilization or progress. She exposes how these "colonial fictions" justify theft of land, suppression of Indigenous knowledge systems, and erasure of sovereignty. Through a careful unpacking of treaties, legal frameworks, and state practices, she reveals how supposed "partnerships" like the Treaty of Waitangi are often used to maintain state control rather than honor Māori autonomy.

The text is not only a critique but a call to action. Ngata urges readers to recognize the systemic nature of colonialism and its embedding in education, governance, and environmental management. She emphasizes the importance of Indigenous resistance, resurgence, and the reclamation of land and language. For Ngata, true justice lies not in inclusion within colonial systems but in their dismantling and the restoration of Indigenous self-determination.

Healing Colonial Wounds and the Sacred Work of Decolonization

The Māori collective that came to the conference consisted of Pāpā Mark Kopua, Diana Kopua, Tina Ngata, James Webster, Hinemoa Jones, Rikki Solomon, and Bronwyn Williams. Through their writing, presentations, and traditional story telling they offered a layered and spiritually grounded approach to healing the personal, collective, and ecological wounds inflicted by the Doctrine of Discovery and colonialism. Drawing from their Māori worldview, they invited us into a framework that, while fully acknowledging the violence of colonial systems, insists that healing must be holistic and sacred. This vision complements and deepens Frantz Fanon's insight that "the first victim of colonial violence is the colonial mind itself." Colonialism

---

[13] Tina Ngata, *Kia Mau: Resisting Colonial Fictions*, 1st ed. (Rebel Press, 2019), https://tinangata.com/2020/06/14/kia-mau-resisting-colonial-fictions/.

[14] Ngata, Kia Mau: Resisting Colonial Fictions.

distorts the humanity of the colonizer as much as it devastates the colonized. Healing, therefore, must address both sides of the colonial wound. Ngata's concept of trauma-informed healing, her critique of "kind colonialism," and her prayers for the colonizer illuminate a spiritual path toward recovering sacredness—in ourselves, each other, and the land.[15]

Ngata is clear that the Doctrine of Discovery functions by stripping people, lands, and waters of their sacredness. In "A Prayer for the Coloniser," she reflects on how this spiritual severance enabled and continues to justify mass violence—from the Great Killing of the Americas to modern human rights abuses. She calls us to pray not only for the colonized but also for the colonizer, not out of sentimentality but because healing cannot be selective. Praying for the colonizer, in her words, is praying for them to "recover their sacredness," and thus reconnect to the taiao (natural world), to ancestral lands, and to the core of their own humanity. In doing so, she honors Fanon's recognition that colonial power deforms the colonizer's soul—it teaches them to deny compassion, empathy, and mutual belonging in order to dominate.[16]

This invitation to pray for the colonizer is radical because it resists the politics of resentment without surrendering to passive reconciliation. It is not forgiveness without justice; rather, it is a prayer for transformation, for dismantling the psychic and structural walls that uphold colonial domination. Ngata's call is a refusal to replicate colonial harm in the name of liberation. Instead, she insists that our resistance must be spiritually grounded and life-affirming. This is also why she critiques "kind colonialism"—the smiling face of empire that cloaks extractive practices in multicultural rhetoric and token gestures. In her essay "Dismantling Kind Colonialism," Ngata warns that structural power does not change simply because its agents speak in gentle tones or wear kākahu to ceremonies. True decolonization demands the dismantling of inherited privilege, settler systems, and the ideologies that naturalize them.

Central to Ngata's healing work is the recognition that colonization impacts not just political structures but also consciousness. In *TUKU* and *It Takes a Kāinga*, she emphasizes that decolonization must involve unlearning internalized colonial values—both for Indigenous peoples and settlers. Healing the colonized mind means unbinding identity from imposed narratives of inferiority, dependence, and brokenness. It also means rekindling Indigenous systems of care, governance, and sacred relationship with the natural world. For the colonizer, healing the colonized mind involves a deep reckoning with the histories they've inherited and denied, and learning how to live *rightly*—with humility, accountability, and reverence.[17]

Fanon warned that when the colonized adopt the worldview of the colonizer, they can perpetuate the very systems that enslaved them. Ngata echoes this in her observations of how colonial behaviors—hoarding power, mistrusting community, replicating domination—can surface even within decolonial movements. Her work thus calls for vigilance and self-awareness. It is not enough to decry empire; we must also decolonize our behaviors, our relationships, and our spiritual assumptions.[18]

---

[15] Tina Ngata, "Dismantling 'Kind' Colonialism," *E-Tangata* (blog), June 16, 2024, https://e-tangata.co.nz/history/dismantling-kind-colonialism/.

[16] Tina Ngata, "A Prayer for the Coloniser," *Tina Ngata: Dismantling Frameworks of Domination, Rematriating Ways of Being* (blog), April 3, 2025, https://tinangata.com/2025/04/03/a-prayer-for-the-coloniser/.

[17] Tina Ngata, "It Takes a Kāinga," *Tina Ngata: Dismantling Frameworks of Domination, Rematriating Ways of Being* (blog), May 13, 2024, https://tinangata.com/2024/05/13/it-takes-a-kainga/; Tina Ngata, "TUKU – the Art of Honouring, and Releasing Mamae," *Tina Ngata: Dismantling Frameworks of Domination, Rematriating Ways of Being* (blog), November 19, 2024, https://tinangata.com/2024/11/19/tuku-the-art-of-honouring-and-releasing-mamae/.

[18] Ngata, "A Prayer for the Coloniser."

In the end, the traditional Māori storytelling provoked and asked us to consider what a sacred, trauma-informed, decolonized future might look like. It would mean the end of settler domination—not just politically, but spiritually. It would mean restoring the sanctity of all beings, including those who once denied it. And it would mean finding, as she puts it, "our way home… to the sacred soils that forged our ancestors." Such a vision is not naive. It is profoundly courageous. And in its full circle, it holds space for both justice and grace.

Doctrine of Christian Discovery Podcast

For those who were unable to attend this historic convening which brought together folks from five continents and over thirty countries, everyone involved with the planning and logistic of this conference are working tireless to create and publish some of the wonderful and important outputs from the conference like in this edited volume and some journals as well. We are collecting all the outcomes into one easy and convenient place (outcome.doctrineofdiscovery.org).

Speaking the Truth: Reflections on the "Doctrine of Christian Discovery" Podcast

A key public-facing component of the conference was the Doctrine of Christian Discovery podcast, hosted by the father-son team of Mitch and Tanner Randall, both proud citizens of the Muscogee Creek.[19] The podcast offered essential commentary, testimony, and analysis from leading voices in the field. This essay summarizes and reflects on each episode of the podcast in numerical order, with a concluding section on its significance and impact.

Episode 1: Betty Hill (Lyons) - Understanding the Doctrine of Christian Discovery

The formal launch of the series features Betty Hill (Lyons) (Onondaga Nation, Snipe Clan), Executive Director of the American Indian Law Alliance. She explains the Doctrine's historical emergence from a series of papal bulls in the 15th century, most notably *Inter Caetera* (1493), which granted Christian colonizers the right to seize land from non-Christian peoples. She emphasizes the ongoing influence of this Doctrine in American legal history, especially through *Johnson v. M'Intosh* (1823). The most striking part of her commentary is the personal and spiritual connection she makes between the land, Indigenous identity, and the desecration wrought by colonialism. Speaking from Onondaga Lake—the "birthplace of democracy"—she reminds listeners that the Doctrine is not merely an ideology, but an ongoing assault on Indigenous people and the land they are inextricably tied to. Her call to action is clear: only by restoring Indigenous legal and spiritual frameworks can peace (or *Skä·noñh*) be possible.

Episode 2: Robert P. Jones - White Supremacy's Roots

Robert P. Jones traces the origins of white supremacy in the United States to the Doctrine of Christian Discovery and its embedment in American legal and cultural systems. He explains how this doctrine, authorized by papal decree in 1493, gave European Christians a divine mandate to conquer and enslave non-Christian peoples, setting a theological and legal precedent for colonization, slavery, and the dispossession of Indigenous peoples. Jones argues that this framework—most visibly embedded in the 1823 Supreme Court case *Johnson v. M'Intosh*—shaped not only U.S. law but also the national mythos, founding documents, and popular memory, all of which still influence public attitudes today. Through personal stories, polling data from PRRI, and examples of truth-telling and reconciliation in local communities like Duluth, Minnesota, Jones calls for a reckoning with this history. He urges that healing, and

[19] Produced by Good Faith Media, with executive producers Mitch Randall, Philip Arnold, Sandy Bigtree, Betty Hill (Lyons), and Adam DJ Brett.

a pluralistic future are only possible through sustained efforts in truth-telling and cross-cultural solidarity between Black and Indigenous communities.

Episode 3: Robert J. Miller – Property & Sovereignty

Law professor and enrolled citizen of the Eastern Shawnee Tribe, Robert J. Miller discusses the Doctrine's role in shaping international and U.S. property law. Miller outlines how European Christian empires used the Doctrine to divide the world through "first discovery," "actual occupancy," and "preemption" rights—principles still embedded in U.S. federal Indian law. Perhaps most troubling is Miller's point that these principles remain good law. He explains that international law functioned to mutually recognize these claims among colonial powers, thereby avoiding conflict—at the expense of Indigenous sovereignty. Miller concludes by urging both legal scholars and citizens to confront the racist, theological underpinnings of U.S. law and property. His episode offers listeners a sobering but crucial realization: legal systems are not neutral—they are built atop religious justifications for conquest.

Episode 4: Gustavo Melo Cerqueira & Danielle Boaz – Religious Racism

This conversation broadens the podcast's geographical scope. Cerqueira and Boaz, both scholars of law and religion, explain how the Doctrine of Christian Discovery functioned as a template for racialized religious persecution across the Americas. Boaz, drawing on her work in Brazil, explores how Afro-Brazilian religions are criminalized under the guise of public safety, echoing centuries-old doctrines that equated non-Christian with non-human. Cerqueira adds that in Latin American constitutional law, Christian norms often shape what counts as religion, freedom, and law. Their dialogue highlights how deeply ingrained Christian normativity is in both North and South American legal systems, effectively marginalizing or erasing Indigenous and African-diasporic spiritualities. This episode shifts the conversation from English common law to the global Catholic and colonial systems that scaffold white supremacy across continents.

Episode 5: Steven Newcomb & JoDe Goudy – U.S. Law

This pivotal episode features two of the most prominent Indigenous legal thinkers working on the Doctrine. Newcomb, author of *Pagans in the Promised Land*, and Goudy, former Chair of the Yakama Nation, reflect on how "domination" became enshrined in federal Indian law. Newcomb insists on calling it the "Doctrine of Christian Domination" to underscore the theological violence that continues today. Goudy shares how awareness of this doctrine has shaped his advocacy, emphasizing the need to move from theory to action. Their exchange is reflective and intergenerational—Newcomb as mentor, Goudy as practitioner—and powerfully illustrates how the Doctrine is not just a legal fiction but a life-determining structure. Their metaphor of being "forced to swim without a lifeboat" underscores the existential stakes for Indigenous peoples navigating U.S. legal frameworks designed to dominate.[20]

Episode 6: Eve Reyes-Aguirre – Environment & Creation

In this episode, Eve Reyes-Aguirre (Izkaloteka Azteca) discusses the Doctrine's ecological dimensions, particularly its impact on land, labor, and environmental justice. Representing Tonatierra, a Phoenix-based cultural embassy for Indigenous peoples, she speaks from the intersection of Indigenous rights, migrant labor, and climate collapse. Reyes-Aguirre links the

[20] Newcomb, Pagans in the Promised Land.

Doctrine of Christian Discovery to capitalist extractivism, drawing a direct line from papal decrees to the exploitation of Indigenous farmworkers today. The Doctrine, she argues, normalized the hierarchy of people and profit over land and life. Particularly moving is her commentary on femicide and environmental degradation as outcomes of spiritual disconnection and legal disenfranchisement. By grounding the conversation in community organizing and activism, she expands the podcast's reach, demonstrating that the Doctrine is as much about poisoned rivers and heat-stressed fields as it is about theology or law.

Episode 7: João Chaves – Influence in the Americas

Chaves explores how U.S. Christian missionary movements helped export the Doctrine across Latin America under the guise of evangelism. Tracing denominational histories, Chaves shows how evangelical Protestant missions often replicated colonial logic by introducing hierarchical, patriarchal, and anti-Indigenous structures into local communities. His critical insight is that colonialism doesn't only happen through armies and courts—it happens through pulpits, Bible translations, and missionary schools. This theological colonization continues to shape the religious landscape of the Americas today. Chaves challenges listeners, especially Christians, to consider how their inherited religious traditions may still be perpetuating colonial worldviews.

Episode 8: Mitch Randall – Countering Conversion

In this final episode, Good Faith Media CEO Mitch Randall (Muscogee Creek) turns the focus inward, reflecting on his own formation as a Southern Baptist minister and his journey toward decolonizing his theology. Randall candidly discusses how missionary frameworks were built on assumptions of spiritual superiority and domination. He critiques "conversion" as a concept when it is used to erase or devalue Indigenous ways of being. His call for repentance is not merely personal, but institutional: churches, denominations, and faith-based media must actively work to dismantle theologies of domination and advocate for Indigenous sovereignty. His voice, as a white Christian leader, is essential—not because it is central, but because it models how accountability and repair can look when done in relationship with Indigenous communities.

Conclusion: Why the Podcast Matters

The *Doctrine of Christian Discovery* podcast is a vital contribution to public theology, decolonial education, and religious literacy. Produced during a historic conference, it extends the reach of the event far beyond Syracuse University. Each episode is a testimony: of harm done, yes—but also of resilience, memory, and the power of Indigenous knowledge. The podcast does not merely inform; it calls its audience into moral and political responsibility.

In a media landscape often saturated with noise, this podcast speaks with clarity and purpose. It features Indigenous voices not as passive victims but as intellectual, legal, and spiritual leaders guiding the way forward. It demystifies the Doctrine of Discovery without simplifying its implications. It draws connections between land, law, labor, and religion, offering listeners a framework to understand how white Christian supremacy operates—then and now.

For students, scholars, clergy, and community organizers, the series is an accessible and essential primer. For Indigenous communities, it affirms what has long been known: that the foundations of modern law and religion are steeped in conquest, but that these foundations can be challenged, reinterpreted, and dismantled.

Acknowledgments

This podcast would not have been possible without the dedication and vision of many. Special thanks to hosts Tanner Randall and Mitch Randall for their thoughtful interviews and reflections; to Good Faith Media for their production leadership; to Philip Arnold, Sandy Bigtree, and Adam DJ Brett for their visionary executive production; and to the many participants and partners including the Indigenous Values Initiative, American Indian Law Alliance, and Syracuse University. This series is more than a podcast—it is a public act of truth-telling and solidarity. May it continue to educate and inspire.

Next Steps for Research and Public Engagement

The Syracuse University conference concluded not with closure but with a series of open-ended questions and commitments. Scholars, activists, and community leaders laid out a multifaceted agenda for moving forward:

1. **Legal Strategies**: Amplify challenges to the Doctrine of Discovery through litigation, particularly by contesting its continued citation in federal Indian law. Legal scholars called for expanding amicus briefs and appeals that center Indigenous law and governance.
2. **Religious Engagement**: Pressure Christian denominations, especially the Roman Catholic Church, to formally rescind—not just repudiate—the papal bulls. Faith communities were urged to produce educational materials and sermons that confront their complicity. Bishop DeDe Duncan-Probe wisely noted that no land acknowledgment is meaningful without tangible action, such as land return.
3. **Public Education**: Expand curriculum projects like "Mapping the Doctrine of Discovery" into public schools, seminaries, and universities. Students from SUNY-ESF and Northern Virginia Community College showed how integrating Indigenous perspectives into classwork, visual storytelling, and poster sessions can catalyze critical reflection. The conference itself served as a model for how education becomes activism.
4. **International Solidarity**: Build alliances with Indigenous peoples from Latin America, the Pacific, Africa, and beyond. Conference sessions highlighted the importance of collaborative advocacy through UN forums, international law, and regional treaty bodies. As attendees noted, the Doctrine's logic of domination is not confined to one continent and must be dismantled everywhere.
5. **Archival Justice**: Invest in Indigenous-led digital archives, oral history projects, and repatriation efforts that document the lived experience and resistance to discovery-based policies. Scholars like Sebastian Modrow emphasized the need to retranslate the papal bulls directly from Latin to recover their original meanings and better challenge their legacy in theological discourse.

Lakeback: Return Maple Bay ~ Restore Our Sacred Onondaga Lake

The *Return Maple Bay ~ Restore Our Sacred Onondaga Lake* campaign is a community-led effort to return Maple Bay, located on the northwest shore of Onondaga Lake, to the Onondaga Nation. Anchored in the #LakeBack movement, the campaign builds on the 2011 and 2016 Onondaga County Legislature resolutions committing to this goal. Onondaga Lake holds sacred, historical, and ecological significance as the birthplace of the Haudenosaunee Confederacy, American democracy, lacrosse, and the women's rights movement. Returning Maple Bay would begin the process of repairing the broken reciprocal relationship between the Onondaga Nation and the lake—a relationship disrupted by colonization, industrial pollution, and ongoing exclusion from land stewardship.

Maple Bay is an ideal starting point for land return because it is one of the least polluted areas of the lake and offers privacy and seclusion suitable for ceremonies and ecological restoration. The campaign connects with the broader #LandBack movement, emphasizing Indigenous sovereignty, ecological restoration, and cultural renewal. The Onondaga Nation approaches caretaking not as ownership but as a sacred responsibility. Principles such as giving thanks, planning for future generations, and maintaining balance with nature guide the Nation's stewardship practices. Restoring access to Maple Bay enables the Onondaga to reestablish ceremonies, protect wildlife, and ensure water quality for future generations.

The campaign is led by the American Indian Law Alliance (AILA) and supported by a growing coalition of organizations and individuals. AILA's strategy combines advocacy, education, coalition-building, and international diplomacy. In addition to organizing community events, developing educational materials, and pursuing heritage designation for the site, the campaign seeks to inspire non-Native communities to support Indigenous leadership in environmental and cultural preservation. Ultimately, *Return Maple Bay* is a call to repair historical injustices by restoring land, honoring treaties, and renewing the life-giving bond between people and water. Learn more by visiting the campaign website lakeback.org.

Pope Francis, Papal Bulls, and a Renewed Call for Justice

The death of Pope Francis, which happened after the conference but before the publication of these proceedings, casts a symbolic shadow over the continuing conversation about the Catholic Church's responsibility for the Doctrine of Discovery. While Francis's papacy acknowledged harm through a 2023 statement denouncing the effects of the bulls, the Church has yet to formally rescind them.

Conference participants, especially, Onondaga Nation Turtle Clan Mother Freida Jacques, Jake Haiwhagai'i Edwards (Onondaga Nation Eel Clan), Philip Arnold, Sandra Bigtree (Mohawk Nation), and Betty Hill (Lyons) (Onondaga Nation, Snipe Clan), emphasized that repudiation without rescission is insufficient. The Doctrine of Discovery must be struck from the canon of Catholic legal theology. Anything less perpetuates a hierarchy of being that justified centuries of genocide.

Francis's moral language about humility and ecological care created openings, but structural change remains unrealized. His passing—or the transition to the next papacy—offers both a risk of regression and an opportunity. The next pope must be challenged to take definitive steps to rescind the bulls and initiate a Vatican-led process of justice for Indigenous peoples. Panel discussions and performances, like George Emilio Sanchez's *In the Court of the Conqueror*, made it abundantly clear: the pain is personal, the call for change urgent.

In honoring Francis's intentions, the Church must now move from symbolic repentance to legal and theological repair. The moment demands clarity, courage, and moral action worthy of the human lives devastated by the Doctrine of Christian Discovery.

Two Row Wampum

In closing, the Two Row Wampum and the One Dish One Spoon Wampum remain guiding frameworks for respectful coexistence and shared responsibility. The Two Row reminds us that distinct peoples can travel side by side, sovereign and in mutual respect, without interference. The One Dish One Spoon teaches that all who share a territory must also share its care—without greed, without violence. As we reflect on the religious origins of white supremacy and chart paths forward, these treaties serve not only as historical agreements but as living ethical commitments to relational accountability, peace, and balance with the land and with one another.